CHAPTER 66

The Third House

GODDESS (THEA)

> Shining face to face with it [the ninth house] is that part of the heaven which rises first from the bottommost regions and brings back the sky once more: it controls the fortunes and fates of brothers; and it acknowledges the Moon as its mistress, who beholds her brother's realms shining on her from the other side of heaven and who reflects human mortality in the dying edges of her face. Goddess (*Dea*) is the name in Roman speech to be given to this region, whilst the Greeks called her by the word in their language (*Thea*).—MANILIUS.[1]

THE ROMAN ASTROLOGER-POET MANILIUS DESCRIBED THE THIRD HOUSE as the temple of the Moon whose name is Goddess. This cadent, declining third house was thought to have low energy and weak support for ordinary worldly business. However, its location also accords it unique qualities as a liminal realm or *metakosmios*, the interspace between worlds. Here ancient astrologers placed religious rites and sacred observances. There was considerable disagreement concerning the favorability of this sector in the ancient literature. Some classified it with the good houses, others with the bad houses, and it hovered between the least bad of the bad and least good of the good. Based upon the underlying geometrical substructure, its good condition came from the mildly benefic sextile to the Ascendant, while its bad condition was due to the inferior position it holds in that configuration.

In modern astrology, the third house is known as the house of communications, siblings, and short journeys. While ancient astrologers generally agreed, they knew the third house first and foremost by the name Goddess—the rejoicing place of the Moon. Many of the significations of the third house familiar to modern astrologers can be traced to the influence of the Moon rather than Mercury. When Hellenistic texts delineate planets in the third house, they frequently describe religious observances, priests and priestesses, sacred rites, and

1 *Astronomia* 2.910–917.